served fragrant waters, and betel leaves filled with betelnut, saffron, and spices.

If there were many merchants from various countries in Cambay then there were also ‘baniyas’* from Cambay in foreign ports, conducting business. The Italian traveller Pietro Della Valle wrote about meeting such merchants in Isfahan, where they regaled him with stories of their home town, and their religion. They told him about the most observant among the Indians, who would ‘neither eat nor kill any living thing’. That they ‘esteem it a good and holy deed to save the life of animals and set them free and very often they buy at high prices birds that other people are keeping in cages…so as to save them from death and set them free…’ They told the Italian about charitable hospitals in Cambay to treat animals and birds, and of the many cows, ‘very beautiful with their horns decorated with gold and jewels…’ So evocatively did they speak about their land that Della Valle finally visited Surat, in 1623, and wrote long letters describing the country.

At Cambay, Akbar was not only able to view the sea but was also able to assess the port and the trade that took place by sea. The annexation of Gujarat was to give to the landlocked Mughal Empire its first access to the sea. There were some fifty or sixty private Portuguese traders as well in Cambay, engaged in buying Gujarati goods to send to Goa, the rest having fled upon hearing of the impending arrival of the Mughal army. Cambay was a prosperous town with fine streets and buildings, and beautiful structures, whose streets were closed off at night with gates. The town had large storage tanks for water and a public hospital to take care of sick and crippled birds of all kinds. Interestingly, a traveller to the region wrote that the Gujaratis of the area were more concerned with ritual purification and pollution through eating than locals in other regions of Hindustan. They dressed in long, thin white gowns and wore red leather shoes, turned up at the ends. Before leaving Cambay, Akbar would cut taxes on the export and import of goods passing through the port, and would allow artisans to settle on the outskirts of the city, measures which would further boost the economy of Cambay, making it the most important Mughal port in Gujarat.

Akbar then ‘boarded a fast-moving boat and ordered that an assembly of pleasure and enjoyment be arranged’ and, according to Qandahari, enjoyed a round of drinks in the briny sea breeze. But, before long, rebellion was brewing again among the Gujarati noblemen whom Abu’l Fazl condemned, describing them as ‘evil-conditioned men’ in whom